

Day 1

After your arrival to Phuntsholing- Jaigaon Border, your guide and driver will welcome you and will assist you with the procedures through Immigration. After you are done, you will check in the hotel. You can spend some time walking around Phuntsholing town and get ready for tomorrow.

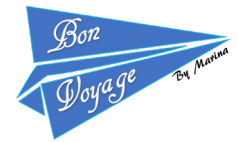
Night halt at Phuntsholing



Day 2

After breakfast, you will check-out from the hotel and start your tour by visiting Kharpandi Goemba on the way to Thimphu which is situated 400 meters above an astonishing valley surrounded by coniferous trees. It is a religious shrine believed to bless infertile couples with children. You then take a long drive

Bon Voyage by Marina



Bhutan - 8 Days, 7 Nights

towards Thimphu the capital city of Bhutan. The distance is approximately 174 kms and goes across spectacular landscapes with waterfalls, small villages and towns and with constantly changing vegetation.



Upon reaching Thimphu, after Lunch you continue your tour by driving to Kuensel Phodrang National Park where you will see a 169 feet bronze statue of Buddha Dordenma overlooking the valley of Thimphu. Popularly known as Buddha View Point, it is one of the largest Buddha statues in the world built to fulfill the prophecy dating back to the 8th century.

You then visit Simply Bhutan, an interactive 'living' museum that gives a quick introduction to various aspects of traditional life in Bhutan. Visitors are greeted with a shot of local arra(rice spirit), before being guided through mocked-up village scenes.

Thereafter you will drive to visit Craft Bazar. A line of bamboo huts stretches along the main street of Thimphu city. It showcases a wide range of authentic Bhutan-made arts and crafts products with reasonable price. Then we proceed to visit Tashichhodzong the largest fortress in Bhutan located on the northern edge of Thimphu City and on the western bank of the Thimphu River. Tashichho Dzong has been the seat of Bhutan's government since 1968 and it presently houses the throne room and offices of the king and also the cabinet secretariat and the ministries of home affairs and finance.

Night Halt in Thimphu

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Kuensel phodrang buddha point



Thimphu



Craft bazar



Tashichho Dzong

Day 3

You start your tour by driving to Motithang Takin Preserve, home to one of the strangest looking creatures in

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the world which is also a national animal of Bhutan. Originally a small zoo, the king decreed that it is against Buddhist practices to pen up animals and was released in the wild. However, the Takin refused to leave wandering the city streets in the search of food and thus the preserve was established under the protection of royal decree.

You will then visit the National Memorial Chorten which is the most visible religious landmark in Bhutan. It was built in 1974 in the memory of third king of Bhutan Jigme Dorji Wangchuck and is located in the southern central part of Thimphu City with its golden spires and bells.

After lunch you will be visiting the National Institute of Zorig Chusum or Art and Crafts Center of Bhutan. The institute provides opportunities for vocational training on the Bhutanese Arts and Crafts. You can witness the students training and give an idea to the visitors on the traditional form of the Arts and Crafts, an interactive 'living' museum that gives a quick introduction to various aspects of traditional life in Bhutan.

Night Halt at Thimpu



Takin zoo



National Memorial chorten



Zorig Chusum



Art and Crafts center

Day 4

After breakfast, you will drive to Punakha the former capital of Bhutan until 1955 and will stop off at Dochula Pass on the way. This popular tourist spot provides stunning 360 degree views of the Himalayas. It is also home to the 108 stupas that were built on a hill to celebrate the victory against the Indian rebels and also in the memory of the soldiers who lost their lives in the battle of 2003.

Now, you will tour one of the most beautiful sites in Bhutan, Punakha Dzong. Sitting at the fork of two rivers, it is a stunning example of Bhutanese architecture. Built in 1637, it is the second oldest and second largest fortress in Bhutan. It was also the location of the royal wedding of Bhutan's current king Jigme Khesar to Jetsun Pema in 2011.

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After that you will visit Punakha Suspension Bridge which is the longest suspension bridge in Bhutan. From the bridge, you can get a spectacular view of the Po Chhu river (male river) and the valley. It's an ideal place for a photoshoot with a stunning background.

(Place is also popular for Rafting if you are interested, speak with guide)

Night Halt at Punakha



Dochula Pass



Punakha Dzong



Punakha Suspension Bridge



Rafting

Day 5

Day excursion to Gangtey

Today, you will travel to Phobjikha (Gangtey) valley known as the winter home of the black-necked crane. On the way you will visit Chimi Lhakhang also known as Fertility Temple which is one of the most popular destinations for visitors in Punakha District and it's located on a small hillock. You will enjoy the 15 minutes' walk through rice field and a small village while your guide narrate an interesting tale about how and why the temple was built.

In Phobjikha, you can see 600 of these elegant, shy birds that migrate here from Tibet between November and March. This bowl-shaped valley is also a wildlife preserve, so you might also see the other native animals to Bhutan, including muntjac, sambar, serow, or yak.

Gangtey Goemba is a 17th-century monastery that sits on a hill, overlooking the entire valley.

An excellent example of Tibetan architecture, the prayer hall (tshokhang), features eight great pillars. In the 15th-century, the Buddhist saint Pema Lingpa foretold that a temple would be built there, so his teachings

Bhutan - 8 Days, 7 Nights

could be spread. In 1613, his grandson, and reincarnation of Pema Lingpa, fulfilled the prophecy by building a Nyingma temple at the location. Kuenzang Chholing, the long white building nearby, is where monks go to meditate for three years, three months, and three days.

While visiting Gangtey Valley, you can also do Gangtey Nature Trails which is the most beautiful and shortest of the existing nature trails in Bhutan. It's around 1 hour pleasurable walk which gives you a nice feeling for Phobjikha Valley. From the small hilltop overlooking Gangtey Goemba heading downhill through flower meadows to Semchubara village and through beautiful forests into the open valley. Along with the trails, you can experience the best out of nature while walking the village enjoying the scenic views of whole U-shaped village. when done with the excursion of Gangtey valley we will drive back to Punakha.

Night Halt at Punakha.



Phojikha (Gangtey)



Chimi Lhakhang



Gangtey Goemba



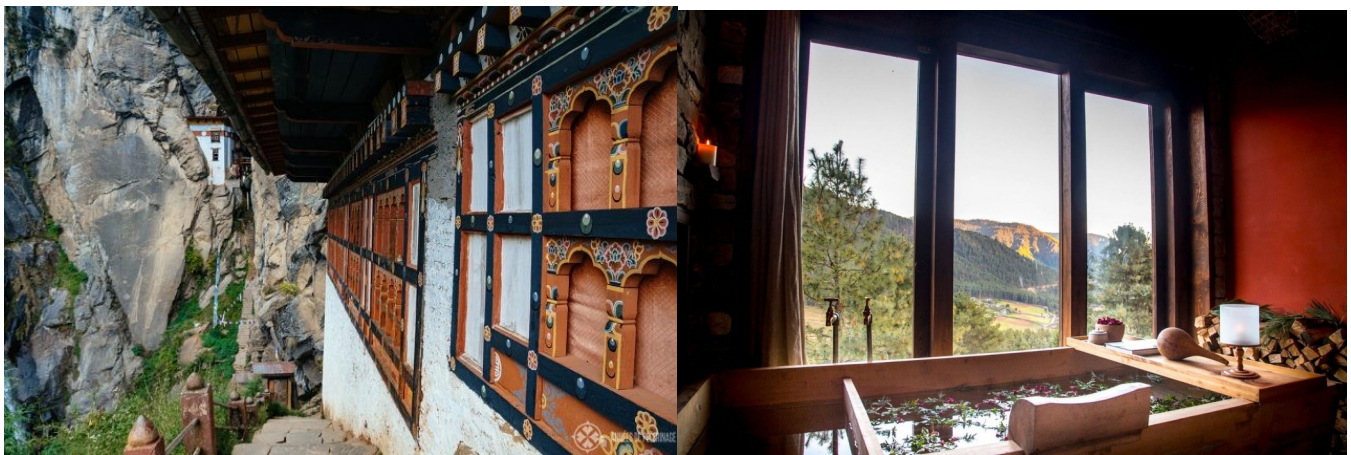
Gangtey Nature Trails

Day 6

After breakfast, you head for **Paro (Rinpung) Dzong** which means Fortress of Jewels because it was built using stones rather than clay. It is an excellent example of 15th-century architecture and one of the most impressive dzongs in Bhutan. It currently serves as the government center of Paro. A cantilever bridge that crossed the river was damaged by fire in 1907 and later washed away by floods, so the original construction was lost.

Located on a hill above Paro Dzong is **Ta Dzong**. This cylindrical watchtower was built in 1649 and converted into the National Museum of Bhutan in 1968. The spiral-shaped building holds antiques, art, textiles, weapons, and household items that tell the history of Bhutan. Today's last Sightseeing will be **Kyichu Lhakhang**, one of the oldest temples in Bhutan built during the 7th century by the Tibetan Emperor. In the evening, we will walk around Paro town and buy souvenirs for your friends and families.

Night halt at a Hotel in Paro.



Day 7

Are you ready? You will be making the hike up to one of the key highlights in Bhutan today! Tiger's Nest aka **Taktsang Monastery**. Taktsang Monastery built on a 900 meters high cliff is the most popular site of Bhutan and the one hour hike to the cafeteria is also a vantage view whereby you can enjoy the stunning view of the monastery. Prayer flags adorn the cliffs and this is also where Guru Padmasambhava landed on the back of a tigress in the 8th century.

In the evening, you will have an opportunity to relax your tired body muscles in a traditional hot Stone bath and enjoy traditional cultural programs as per your interest.

Night halt at Paro.



Taktshang Monastery or the Tiger's Nest Monastery

Day 8

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After breakfast you will be driven back to Phuentsholing and you will bid farewell to this beautiful Himalayan country and take drive back. We hope by now you would have made some friends and also kept many photos and beautiful memories of Bhutan.

